2.2 Competition for Territory and the French Revolution

George Washington had dealt with many challenging situations, but as president, he probably got more than he bargained for. As political conflict grew among U.S. citizens, conflicts over western lands heated to the boiling point.

MAIN IDEA As the young republic pushed west, conflicts both at home and abroad caused a host of challenges for the United States.

CONFLICTS IN THE WEST

The problem area was the Northwest Territory, located north of the Ohio River, between the western boundary of Pennsylvania and the Mississippi River. As you may remember, the Treaty of Paris of 1783 had established new boundaries for the United States and tried to settle claims on this land. But in the 1790s, the land seemed to be up for grabs once again. Spain, Britain, the United States, and Native American groups all claimed parts of the vast expanse for their own.

The United States mostly fought with Native Americans over rights to this land. Americans wanted to settle the land, not only for its rich soil but also for its minerals, such as copper, iron, and silver. Native Americans had lived in this region for thousands of years and attacked settlers who moved onto the land. In response, Washington sent in two military expeditions, but the Miami of Ohio, led by Chief Little Turtle, defeated them both. Then, in 1794, federal troops defeated the Miami at the Battle of Fallen Timbers. The British, who had usually helped the Miami, refused to protect them this time. They were tired of war. Without British support, the Miami and other Native Americans in the region signed the **Treaty of Greenville**, which **ceded**, or gave up, their lands in present-day Ohio and Indiana to the United States.



Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York

Washington Reviewing the Western Army at Fort Cumberland, Maryland depicts Washington arriving to review the militia during the Whiskey Rebellion. The president's mere presence was enough to put an end to the protestors' armed attacks. The episode demonstrated how much people respected Washington and the central government. Artist Frederick Kemmelmeyer created the painting sometime after 1795—shortly after the rebellion took place.

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Meanwhile, another conflict brewed in western Pennsylvania. Farmers had been protesting a whiskey tax, claiming it was unfair. Secretary of the Treasury Alexander Hamilton had proposed the tax, which was passed by Congress in 1791 to raise money to pay down the national debt. The angry farmers who made, consumed, sold, and traded whiskey, tarred and feathered tax collectors and threatened armed attacks in what is known as the **Whiskey Rebellion**. President Washington sent nearly 13,000 soldiers into the region to demonstrate the power of the federal government. The rebels soon stood down.

THE FRENCH REVOLUTION

Across the Atlantic, the people in France were involved in a rebellion of their own. They sought to put an end to upper-class privilege and demanded equality for the lower classes. Many in the United States, and particularly the Democratic-Republicans, supported the **French Revolution**. But then in 1793, **radicals**, or people who support complete social or political change, executed the French king, Louis XVI. France then declared war on Spain, Britain, and other neighboring nations. In this international conflict, the Federalists sided with Britain, thereby increasing the division between the two American parties. So even though France had supported the American Revolution, Washington declared in 1793 that the United States would remain neutral, not taking sides with anyone.

But Britain made neutrality difficult. Its Royal Navy captured American citizens and forced them to work on British ships. They also blocked trade in the British West Indies and seized American ships. To make peace, Washington sent Chief Justice John Jay to England to work out a deal. Jay's Treaty required the British to pay for the American ships they had damaged, but it failed to reopen trade in the West Indies.

Meanwhile, **Thomas Pinckney**, an American statesman, traveled to Spain and negotiated Pinckney's Treaty in 1796 to maintain friendly relations between the United States and Spain. The treaty opened the Mississippi River to free navigation, allowed Americans to use the Spanish port of New Orleans, and settled a conflict regarding the Spanish colony of West Florida.



Guillotine
One of the most striking images of the French Revolution is the guillotine (GEE-yuh-teen), the machine used to execute thousands, including Louis XVI. The guillotine had a blade that plunged down grooves in two upright posts to slice through the victim's neck, beheading him or her in one stroke.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why did farmers in western Pennsylvania stage the Whiskey Rebellion?
2. **IDENTIFY PROBLEMS AND SOLUTIONS** Describe the conflicts between American settlers and Native Americans in the Northwest Territory and how they were resolved.
3. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why do you think the United States wanted to remain neutral during the French Revolution?

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